

CHAPTER IX

MAIMONIDES AND HUMANITY

THE vision of Maimonides, like that of Genesis and Job, of the prophets and the psalms, is "beyond the border of Israel," and it would be wrong, even in so brief a sketch as this, to omit reference to his conception of humanity as a whole. In brief it may be said that as his outlook is a religious one, there is no difference in principle for him between the chosen race and any other. The Bible gives the Jew unique opportunities: the way of life it lays down smoothes his ascent to higher things, and the beliefs it inculcates are portions of the truth which is an essential part of human perfection. But both way of life and essential truths are not hidden mysteries; they are open to all with eyes to see and ears to hear. "And why did not Levi have a share with his brethren in the inheritance of the land of Israel and in the spoil?" Maimonides asks in the course of a passage in the *Code* (*Release and Jubilee* xiii, 12-3); and answers in the words of the Bible: "Because he was set apart to worship God and to serve him and to teach his upright ways and righteous judgments to the many." He then adds: "And not the tribe of Levi only, but *any man born into the world* whose spirit has moved him freely and whose understanding has taught him to set himself apart and stand before God to serve him and worship him in order to know God; anyone who walks upright as God made him and has thrown off from his neck the yoke of the 'many inventions made by men' [the phraseology is from Ecclesiastes vii, 29]—such a one is sanctified with the sanctity of the holy of holies, and God will be his portion and his inheritance for ever and unto all eternity."

The same point is put most vividly in a letter (ed. Freimann, xlii) written by Maimonides to a convert to Judaism who seems to have felt himself inferior to a Jew "by blood," and who brought his trouble to the Master: "Let not thy descent be light in thine eyes. If *our* descent is from Abraham, Isaac and Jacob, *thy* descent is from God himself; and so it is

expressly stated in the book of Isaiah: 'One shall say: I am the Lord's; another shall call himself by the name of Jacob.' "

A reconciliation between particularism and universalism could hardly be more nobly suggested or more neatly fathered on a Biblical text. All men alike are called to the Divine Presence, and it is the Jew's function, as it is the purpose of the Bible, to help them on the way; but "any man born into the world," whether Jew or not, can dedicate himself to "stand before God," and he is then "sanctified with the sanctity of the holy of holies." And so Maimonides refused to call either Christianity or Islam heathen. They are stages in the upward movement of humanity and as such to be welcomed and given their place.

Thus we do not find in Maimonides, as we do in his predecessor and anti-type, the poet-philosopher Judah Hallevi (1085-1140), the conception of an exclusive connection between religion and the Jewish people, or between religion and Palestine, or between such religious phenomena as prophecy and the geographical conditions of Palestine. Judaism for him is not a product of "race" or an inheritance of "blood," nor is it bound up exclusively with any one people or any one soil. The tribe of Levi is only an exemplar of a self-dedication which is open to all men alike. True Abraham is "our father"; but not only "after the flesh." "Thou hast asked about the blessings and the prayers" (he writes to the convert in the letter already quoted), "and whether thou should say: 'our God and the God of our fathers' and 'who hast sanctified us with his blessings' and 'who hast given our fathers an inheritance' and 'hast brought us up out of the land of Egypt' and 'didst work miracles for our fathers,' and the rest of the traditional allocutions.

"Thou shouldst use them all and change nothing but shouldst pray as any native Jew, whether thou prayest in private or whether thou leadest the congregation in prayer. The root of the matter is that Abraham our father was he who taught the whole people and instructed them and made them acquainted with the religion of truth and the uniqueness of God, and spurned idolatry and destroyed its worship and

brought many under the wings of the Divine Presence and taught them and instructed them and ordered his children and household after him to keep the way of God, as it is written in the Law: 'for I have known him to the end that he may command his children and his household after him that they may keep the way of the Lord, to do justice and judgment.' Therefore every stranger who joins us to the end of time, and everyone who recognizes the unity of God as taught in Scripture, is a disciple of Abraham our father, and they are all of them members of his household and he it is who brought them to the right path.

"And therefore thou art to say: 'our God and the God of our fathers' because Abraham is thy father. . . . There is no difference between us and thee in any thing. Thou mayest certainly say in thy prayers 'Who hath chosen us' and 'Who hath given us the Law' and 'Who hath caused us to inherit' and 'Who hath separated us,' because God hath indeed chosen thee and separated thee from the peoples and given thee the Law; for the Law is given alike to us and to the stranger, as it is written: 'O congregation, there is one statute for ye and for the stranger that dwelleth among ye'; 'an everlasting statute for your generations, alike for ye and for the stranger before the Lord'; 'one Law and one judgment is there for ye and for the stranger who sojourneth with ye.'

"Know this: Our fathers who went up from Egypt were, in Egypt, idolaters for the most part: they had mixed with the nations and learned of their ways; until God sent Moses our teacher and brought them under the wings of the Divine Presence, us and the strangers together, and gave us all one statute."

True, the word "stranger" used throughout is the technical word for a convert. But "the resident stranger" is a non-Jew who has undertaken to give up idolatrous worship and to fulfil the other "Noachide commandments,"¹ and as such is received,

¹ The "seven commandments of the sons of Noah" (i.e., the natural moral code) concerning "justice between man and man, the prohibition of idol worship, of blasphemy, of incest, of murder, of theft, and of eating parts cut from living animals" (T. B. San. 75a f.). On the whole subject, see the essay of N. Isaacs in the *Legacy of Israel*, p. 383 ff. and cf. my note, *ib.*, p. 444.

although without circumcision and baptism, as one of the "pious of the nations of the world" (*Code, Forbidden Intercourse* xiv, 6). The "pious of the nations of the world"—i.e., non-Jews who have abjured idolatry and adopted the "natural" moral law—have, in accordance with a well-known Rabbinical dictum cited by Maimonides (*Repentance* iii, 4, cf. *Eduth* xi, 10), a "portion in the world to come" as well as the Jew; and Maimonides, in laying it down (*Code, Kings* x, 12) that they should be treated, both in ordinary intercourse and when they are in need, in the same way as a fellow-Jew, quotes the verse: "God is good to all and his tender mercies are over all his works" (Psalm cxlv, 9). There is no wonder then that he could end this letter with the passage which has been quoted already but which is well worth quoting again: "Let not thy descent be light in thine eyes; if *our* descent is from Abraham, Isaac and Jacob, *thy* descent is from God himself."

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The points touched on may be deepened and illustrated by a reference to two chapters of the *Code*, the one on the origin of idolatry, the other on the Messianic age. These chapters introduce us to Maimonides' views on the opening and the close of human history as a social phenomenon. (From the point of view of the *individual*, as we have seen [above, p. 115 f., the end is not the "Messianic Age" but the "world to come".) History is to close, as it opened, with a unified humanity united in the worship of the one God.

We may turn to the fourth section, "On Idolatry"¹, of the Book of Knowledge (the first book of the *Code*):

The relapse of humanity into idolatry. "In the days of Enoch the people fell into gross error. . . . They said: 'Since God created these stars and spheres to guide the world, set them on high and allotted unto them honour, and since they are ministers who minister before Him, they deserve to be praised and glorified, and honour should be rendered them; and it is

¹ Cap. i, condensed (trans. Hyamson). The paragraph headings are from the present writer.

the will of God, blessed be He, that men should aggrandise and honour those whom He aggrandised and honoured, just as a king desires that respect should be shown to the officers who stand before Him, and thus honour is shown to the king.' When this idea arose in their minds, they began to erect temples to the stars, offered up sacrifices to them, praised and glorified them in speech and prostrated themselves before them—their purpose, according to their perverse notions, being to obtain the Creator's favour. This was the root of idolatry. . . .

Abraham re-discovers the truth. "The world moved on in this fashion, till the patriarch Abraham was born. He began to reflect by day and night: 'How is it possible that this [celestial] sphere should continuously be guiding the world and have no one to guide it and cause it to turn round; for it cannot be that it turns round of itself.' He had no teacher, no one to instruct him in aught. He was submerged, in Ur of the Chaldees, among foolish idolaters. His father and mother and the entire population worshipped idols, and he worshipped with them. But his mind was busily working and reflecting till he had attained the way of truth and knew that there is one God who guides the celestial sphere and created everything, and that among all that exist, there is no god beside Him. . . .

Abraham the reformer and image-breaker. "Having attained this knowledge, he began to refute the inhabitants of Ur of the Chaldees, arguing with them and saying to them: 'the course you are following is not the way of truth.' He broke the images and commenced to instruct the people that it was not right to serve any one but the God of the Universe. . . .

Abraham takes his message to the wider world. "He then began to proclaim to the whole world with great power and to instruct the people that the entire universe had but one Creator and that Him it was right to worship. He went from city to city and from kingdom to kingdom, calling and gathering together the inhabitants till he arrived in the land of Canaan. There too he proclaimed his message, as it is said: 'and he called there on the name of the Lord, God of the Universe' (Gen. xxi, 33). When the people flocked to him and questioned

him regarding his assertions, he would instruct each one according to his capacity till he had brought him to the way of truth, and thus thousands and tens of thousands joined him. These are the persons referred to in the phrase 'men of the house of Abraham.'

Abraham founds a family to carry on his work. The family becomes a "people that know God." "This great doctrine Abraham taught to Isaac his son, and Isaac settled down, instructing and exhorting. Isaac imparted the doctrine to Jacob and ordained him to teach it. He too settled down, taught and morally strengthened all who joined him, and instructed all his sons. He set apart Levi as a teacher and placed him in a college to teach the way of God and keep the charge of Abraham, and charged his sons to appoint one instructor after another from the tribe of Levi, in uninterrupted succession, so that the doctrine might never be forgotten. And so it went on with ever increasing vigour among Jacob's children and their adherents till they became a people that knew God.

This people relapse into idolatry. "When the Israelites had stayed a long while in Egypt, they relapsed, learnt the practices of their neighbours, and, like them, worshipped idols, with the exception of the tribe of Levi, which steadfastly kept the charge of the patriarch and never practised idolatry. The doctrine implanted by Abraham would, in a very short time, have been uprooted, and Jacob's descendants would have relapsed into the error and perversities universally prevalent.

The people under Moses are chosen again. "But because of God's love for us and because He kept the oath made to our ancestor Abraham, He appointed Moses to be our teacher and the teacher of all the prophets, and charged him with his mission. After Moses had begun to exercise his prophetic functions and Israel had been chosen by the Almighty as His heritage, he crowned them with precepts, and showed them the way to worship Him and how to deal with idolatry and with those who go astray after it."

The Jews are thus in idea a missionary people, a people that, in spite of relapses, "know God," and their mission is to teach the faith of Abraham which is nothing other than the

original faith which united all mankind. The completion of the mission will mark an epoch in human history in which the potentialities of all mankind will become actual, and not only individuals but all men together will "walk upright as God made them." We thus come again to Maimonides' account of the Messiah and the Messianic age. We have already seen his first sketch in the *Commentary* (above, p. 113). We can now study it in its final form as laid down in the *Code*.

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In brief, it may be said that for Maimonides (*a*) the Messiah is a terrestrial king, the restorer of the house of David and the re-founder of an earthly dynasty, and he is thus not so much a person as the inaugurator of a new epoch in human history; (*b*) the Messianic age inaugurated by the restoration of the Davidic line will be an age of plenty, righteousness and peace; (*c*) this universal peace will give the opportunity for the development of those higher capacities of mind and soul which under present conditions are crippled and suppressed; and (*d*) in those days all men, if they are worthy, and not the hereditarily chosen few only, may serve.

Without commenting again on the resolution of the ancient issue between "Israel" and the "Gentiles" (or, in modern phrase, that between nationalism and internationalism) which would seem to be effected in this outlook, I quote some specific passages, hoping that the quaintness of some of the expressions used will not obscure the vitality of the thought:

"The king Messiah is destined to arise and bring the Davidic kingdom back to its former glory. . . . He will build the Temple and assemble the scattered children of Israel, and all the old laws will be restored . . . and he will bring the whole world to a united worship of God as it is written (Zephaniah iii, 9): 'For then will I turn to the peoples a pure language that they may all call on the name of the Lord, to serve him with one consent.'

"It should not be imagined that in the Messianic days the order of nature will be disturbed or the ways of the world

changed, for its normal course will continue. But the wicked will all be turned to the religion of truth and neither rob nor destroy. . . . The Messiah comes neither to make impure the pure or to make pure the impure [that is, to alter the ceremonial law], but to establish peace in the world. . . . The wise men and the prophets longed for the Messianic days not in order that they should be masters of all the world, have rule over the Gentiles, or be exalted by the nations, and not in order that they should eat and drink and rejoice, but in order that they should be free to study the Law and its wisdom, and that there should not be over them an oppressor to deter them from it. . . . And at that time there shall be neither hunger nor war nor jealousy and strife, for there will be great abundance and delicate foods will be plentiful as the dust; and the whole world will be occupied with one thing only, namely, the knowledge of God. Men will therefore be of great wisdom, and they will understand hidden things and attain knowledge of their creator in so far as men can, as it is written (Is. xii, 9): 'for the earth shall be full of the knowledge of the Lord, as the waters cover the sea.' "

This is the concluding passage of the *Code*, and it sets the seal on that extensive work. The *Code* opens with a majestic statement of first principles: "The foundation of foundations and the pillar of all wisdom is the knowledge that there is a first Existent who brings into being all that is." It then offers a complete recapitulation of the whole compass of Jewish law, moral, civil, criminal and ceremonial. At the last, in the passage above quoted, it ends with the vision of that knowledge as the common possession of all mankind.

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Enough has been said to show that in Maimonides' Judaism we have much more than an exclusive nationalism on the one hand or an empty rationalism on the other. It is a full and generous creed, firmly based in history and deeply rooted in a sense of vocation. Much has been made by recent historians of Judaism of the contemporary complaints that at the great

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religious crises culminating with the expulsion of all Jews from Spain, it was the philosophers who gave way and accepted Catholicism, whereas the women and ignorant remained steadfast in their own faith¹; as if the philosophical approach to Judaism had been a canker which had been eating away at the tree and finally rotted and destroyed it. Yet it should be remarked that the final expulsion from Spain took place three whole centuries after the publication of the *Guide*; and if the philosophical movement had only served to keep the perplexed within the fold for three hundred years, its achievement was, to say the least, remarkable. Indeed, the noblest representative of the period, the great Isaac Abrabanel, statesman and scholar and Biblical exegete, who after pleading for his people in vain, went with them into exile—Isaac Abrabanel and many others who did not give way owed their intellectual background and moral steadfastness, if to any one thing, to the example and doctrine of Maimonides.

We are being told now again that salvation is of the mystics, and are being redirected to the incoherences of the Kabbala. It is from such phantasmagoria that the clear stream of Maimonidean rationalism can preserve us, now as much as then. Rationalism, says the Oxford Dictionary, is "(a) the practice of explaining in a manner agreeable to reason whatever is apparently supernatural in the records of sacred history; or (b) the principle of regarding reason as the chief or only guide in matters of religion." It would be fair to call Maimonides a rationalist in both these senses. But it is essential to add that no sane rationalist ever thought that the "records of sacred history" or "matters of religion" are deducible from abstract definitions acquired *a priori*. Religious truth, it must be conceded, arises in the heart. All that the rationalist asks is that, as has been well remarked,² it should come out through the head.

¹ Some significant texts in my *Illustrations*, cap. vi.

² I think by John Morley. One might add, as a twentieth century comment, a remark from a character in Somerset Maugham: "I'll give you my opinion of the human race in a nutshell, brother. Their heart's in the right place, but their head is a thoroughly inefficient organ."

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Maimonides' claim on the history of thought is that he worked out the logic of monotheism, his claim on the history of Judaism that he impressed "form" on the inchoate "matter" of the tradition. Yet the two claims are not distinct, since monotheism is the principle of order, and Judaism, in Maimonides' view, is monotheism. It is as a protagonist of monotheism that Maimonides stands or falls.

Monotheism has two aspects, positive and negative. It can offer a definite doctrine of God, and it can fight against mythology and superstition. Maimonides' contribution was to the second aspect rather than to the first: like Moses on the mount, when he drew near to God he found darkness. Yet even his negative theology allowed room for a positive moral doctrine; and if it did not offer a positive theory of God of its own, it at least destroyed many false theories of others, and its own great faith in a world-order, which it is the function of reason to reveal, is a much needed bulwark against the forces which threaten to engulf us too.

Perhaps it is this astringent quality of Maimonides which makes him so memorable. Here is no "wishful thinking," no gross pictorialism, no pandering to human megalomania. Things are what they are, and each thing exists for its own sake; the mind can only ponder facts. Yet its outlook is forward: "the eyes are directed ahead and not back." "The people that walked in darkness have seen a great light."

§

This metaphor of light with which the *Guide* concludes (III, liv, 397), and which indeed is found repeatedly throughout the whole book, suggests a last significant point. Religion is light, only as much light, perhaps, as our eyes can bear; but it is still light. It is no "opium for the people," no "falsehood," however "noble," invented by Platonizing rulers in order to keep down the ruled. There is for Maimonides one truth only; and religion embodies that truth in a form understandable by the ordinary man.

This view stands in sharp contrast with another and

historically more prevalent one, according to which there are *two* truths, one for the thinker and one for the ordinary man, and the thinker *qua* thinker might think differently from what he would think as an ordinary man, and so contain within himself a double (and corrupt) intellectual personality. "What is true in philosophy can be false in theology, what is true in theology, false in philosophy"; and thus one and the same man might maintain at one and the same time on one and the same matter two contradictory propositions. This doctrine, associated popularly, although apparently wrongly, with the name of Maimonides' great contemporary, the Arab philosopher Averroes, was upheld by Averroes' Christian followers; and although it was combatted by the Church it gradually seeped into European thought and made much of it hollow and unsubstantial.

Against this cleavage in the mind of man the whole Maimonidean outlook is a protest. For Maimonides religious truth is philosophical truth, howbeit adapted to ordinary comprehension, and both religion and philosophy are rooted in the organized knowledge which is known in our day as science. The human mind is one; and human intelligence, although more developed perhaps in one man than another, is in all men the same. There is then only one truth, however varied our approaches to it and however various the degrees of our apprehension of it.

This insistence on the unity of truth involves the essential integrity of the human mind. The object presented to the mind is one just as is the aim which is set before it; its activities are therefore one. Human knowledge as a whole is an attempt to reveal and to embody the unity of the created world, and the unity of the created world only reveals and embodies the unity of the creator. The One created one; the one strives to the One; and the medium between them, the mind of man, is also one, interpreting, through the knowledge which is science, the traces in the one world of the one God.

EPILOGUE

I HAVE tried in this volume to give a general account of a great medieval figure; but I have tried to reveal not his medievalism but his greatness, and may thus have been led into "modernization." In that case I can only offer the reflection that in their own day medieval thinkers too were modern.

But it is a pity that sound doctrine should receive a date at all. That religion has an intellectual content; that thinking matters; that human actions can be trained and that social institutions have an educational reference; that living demands discipline and that virtue should ask for no reward—these and similar characteristic teachings of Maimonides would seem to deserve attention even though they were enunciated (and not by him alone) many centuries ago. We may reject (though why should we?) his vision of God as the centre towards which all creation yearns; but we should do well to ponder many other lessons, both general and specific, and perhaps learn from them for our own need: that Biblical texts in order to remain fruitful must be re-interpreted; that it is presumptuous to pretend to an intimate acquaintance with God; that the world is an ordered whole open to the mind of man; that science describes but does not explain; that design and law do not conflict, and that law and not miracle is the sign-manual of deity; that human progress, even into eternity, is spiritual; that all knowledge is revelation and all thinking inspiration; that pessimism is self-obsession and asceticism sin. All this is "modern" enough however couched in obsolete words and supported by learned reference to forgotten authority. After all, life is much the same in every age.

If the ideal is to make all things transparent to the intelligence, Maimonides' achievement must be reckoned very high. He reduced to intelligible principle the matter not only of physics and metaphysics but also of an intricate code of belief and conduct embodying in copious measure both present prescription and ancient survival. True, the foundations of his view of the world are (for his time) conventional; but his

originality consisted in harmonizing it with a religious text and an historical code and welding them all together into one whole. When estimating his labours it is their extent as well as their detail which commands, first, admiration and then astonishment. As a conciliator he remains unsurpassed.

And yet he offers us a problem, not a solution, and we shall turn to him in vain for a summary resolution of our own doubts. Every age has its own vocabulary, and the vocabulary of our thinking must be our own. The doctrine of the necessity of allegory and creative interpretation holds even against the master himself. Maimonides' words are not ours nor is his science the science of our generation. The "scriptures" still "talk in the language of men" but the language of men has changed. The ultimate question for us is not therefore what Maimonides actually said but what Maimonides would have said if he had lived in our day. Can the spirit of his teaching be made of significance to us although its matter is outmoded?

This question each reader must answer for himself, and he will do so best through a re-living of the life, and a re-thinking of the thought, of the historical figure we have been studying. We must be set down in the midst of the valley of the dry bones before we can attempt to quicken them.

We should turn therefore in gratitude to the work of those scholars who have taught us the plain meaning of the texts and given us a true picture of the circumstances which produced them. Some guide to their labours is offered in the Note which follows. It is hoped that with their help the reader will pursue the subject further in its philological detail until, in the words attributed to the master of Maimonides' own master, "after a long period of close companionship, it is suddenly, like a blaze kindled by a leaping spark, generated in the soul and becomes self-sustaining."

NOTE ON LITERATURE

A FULL treatment of the life, work and influence of Maimonides is to be found in the series of monographs contained in the composite volumes *Moses ben Maimon* (Frankfurt a. M., vol. 1, 1908; vol. 2, 1914), edited by W. Bacher, M. Brann and D. Simonsen, and a concise summary of his philosophy in its historical setting in Professor Julius Guttman's standard *Philosophie des Judenthums* (1933). For English readers there is the brief *Maimonides* of D. Yellin and I. Abrahams (Jewish Worthies Series, London, 1903), and that of S. Zeitlin (New York, 1935); the chapter on Maimonides in I. Husik's *History of Jewish Medieval Philosophy* (New York, 1916); the VIII Centenary Memorial Volume *Moses Maimonides* (with complete English bibliography), edited by I. Epstein (London, 1935); and *Essays on Maimonides, An Octocentennial Volume*, edited by S. W. Baron (Columbia University Press, 1941). For the general background the *Legacy of Israel*, ed. I. Abrahams, E. R. Bevan, and C. Singer (Oxford, 1927), should be consulted.

On Maimonides as a philosopher there is the volume of L. L. Lévy, *Maïmonide*, in the *Grands philosophes* series (Paris, Alcan, 1911), and reference should be made to the bibliography in the *History of Philosophy* of Ueberweg-Heinze (ed. Baumgartner, Berlin, 1915). New ground has been broken in the numerous special studies of H. A. Wolfson and in the suggestive essay of L. Strauss, *Farabi's Plato*, in the Ginzberg Jubilee Volume (New York, 1945). A volume of selected texts, with an introduction by Professor Julius Guttman, is promised in the East and West Library (Phaedon Press).

The principal editions and translations of Maimonides' works and other aids to the student have been mentioned in the course of this book. A recent systematic account, referring to all important books and articles dealing with Maimonides, is to be found in the introduction to the new and much improved Hebrew text of the *Guide* which has just been published on the authority of the manuscripts and early printed editions by Dr. J. Ibn-Shemuel (Kaufman), Jerusalem, 1946.